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VENTURE



Rex Salisbury's Cambrian Ventures raises new fund, bucking fintech slowdown



Marina Temkin — 7:43 AM PDT · July 16, 2025

Rex Salisbury, the solo GP behind [Cambrian Ventures](#), fondly recalls the time he fell in love with fintech.

The year was 2015; he had recently left his job as an investment banker to try his hand at engineering at a mortgage startup in San Francisco. “That’s when you had companies like Stripe, Plaid, Credit Karma, Wealthfront starting to scale,” he told TechCrunch. “Lending Club had just done their IPO, and was trading really well.”

Investors’ excitement for fintech grew exponentially in the following years, reaching a fever pitch in 2021. Things calmed down noticeably a year later, however, as interest rates rose.

Today, many think fintech has lost its luster, but Salisbury’s enthusiasm for the category remains as strong as it did in 2015. He feels the popular opinion that most opportunities in fintech have been exhausted could not be further from the truth. “If you’re a specialist and you know where to look, you’ll realize that only 1% of global financial services revenues has been captured by fintech,” he said.

Indeed, Salisbury has been busy investing in pre-seed and seed-stage startups from Cambrian’s [inaugural \\$20 million fund](#). Of the 33 companies he has funded, Salisbury claims about half have already secured Series A funding, considerably higher than the 15.4% seed-to-Series A graduation rate [tracked by Carta](#).

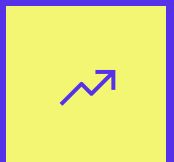
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These companies include [Simple Closures](#), which helps startups close shop, and [Keep](#), a Canadian credit card and payments platform.

Salisbury credits the first fund's performance with his ability to find strong founders "who are very good at executing against the vision they lay out."

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That early success has now helped Salisbury secure a second fund, which is launching with \$20 million in committed capital.

The haul is a remarkable feat for a small venture fund like Cambrian: A [report by PitchBook](#) showed that fundraising by emerging venture managers (defined as firms still running their first three funds) hit a decade low in the first half of 2025.

Salisbury isn't just another fintech investor, however. Before launching Cambrian Ventures, he was the founding member of Andreessen Horowitz's (a16z) fintech practice. And during his several years at the prominent firm, he invested in a startup called

Deel, which would go on to become a giant in the payroll and human resource tools space.

Prior to joining a16z, Salisbury founded a fintech community that hosted monthly meetups for founders, builders, and sector enthusiasts. He also launched a newsletter that soared to about 20,000 subscribers, and runs a Slack group that now boasts over 1,800 founders.

Thanks to his well-regarded network, Salisbury attracted founders from top fintech companies like NerdWallet, Plaid, Betterment, and Melio as LPs for his first fund. These individuals returned to invest in his second fund, which also saw the addition of several institutional backers, including a bank and a life insurance firm.

Salisbury says his strategy remains unchanged for Cambrian’s second fund, explaining that he is still focused on “finding great founders who have new ideas for unique products.”

Of course, what’s different now is that startups can leverage all the advancements in AI. “The biggest thing AI lets you do is build multi-product companies from day one,” he said.

“AI makes it easier to write more code that does more things,” he explained, pointing to his investment in [Every](#). “They do banking, accounting, finance, corporation tax, treasury, HR, HSA, FSA, and a few other things, all in one.”

Topics: [a16z](#) [Cambrian Ventures](#) [Fintech](#) [solo GP](#)

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Marina Temkin

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Why does a16z need its own Y Combinator?

Natasha Mascarenhas — 1:43 PM PDT · April 18, 2022

For over a year, Andreessen Horowitz has quietly piloted its own take on an accelerator for early-

stage entrepreneurs, and today, the firm announced the program’s official debut.

In exchange for an unannounced percentage of ownership, “a16z START” will offer early-stage founders up to \$1 million in venture capital. The checks are backed by a [\\$400 million seed fund](#), which closed in August 2021.

[Andreessen Horowitz unveils piloted program for early-stage entrepreneurs](#)

The remote-first program will accept founders on a rolling basis and wants to connect folks with partners for advice, potential customers or investors, and of course, other entrepreneurs.

On the relatively brief application form for START, a16z names six categories — American dynamism, consumer, enterprise, fintech, games or other. Investment terms will be discussed with final candidates, the form says.

This program extends Andreessen Horowitz’s stamp of approval to the earliest step of an entrepreneur’s journey: the idea stage, or the pre-quitting-your-day-job part of startup life. The company has invested in solo founders before their companies ever existed, but this program appears to be a more formal effort to bring folks into entrepreneurship. Notably, there is no mention of a diversity mandate or focus.

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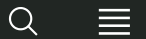
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The list of early participants in this program shows that a16z is certainly interested in international entrepreneurs, similar to how Y Combinator has

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a16z has often led some of the buzziest rounds coming out of Y Combinator, including Tandem, Queenly and Contra — essentially sourcing deal flow from the accelerator.

Yet, hungry founders and boatloads of capital have encouraged investors in recent quarters to go early themselves, legacy be damned.

TFW a16z and YC want the same spot

[Given the rapid proliferation of startups](#) over the years, both a16z and Y Combinator have a ton of

options to plant their capital. Yet, systemic diversity issues across the industry mean that their portfolios could look quite homogenous.

Since first running the program in fall 2021, a16z has received over 1,000 applications and accepted 11 entrepreneurs, which works out to a 1.1% acceptance rate. For comparison's sake, Y Combinator received 17,000 applications and accepted 414 entrepreneurs for its latest batch for a 2.4% acceptance rate.

a16z declined to share how many founders will be accepted into the program, but it appears that the application-to-acceptance ratio will be similar in rigor to what Y Combinator has reached over time.

Both firms are challenged by tougher deal access and higher startup valuations today than in prior years. As Y Combinator has grown, the firm increased its investment size, which now includes a simple agreement for future equity with a “most favored nation” clause.

Reading between the lines, Y Combinator has decided to be more aggressive in its pursuit of ownership in portfolio companies, meaning that it can put more money to work when those dollars buy the most shares. a16z likely wants the same setup, even if it likely puts it into somewhat direct competition with the venerable accelerator.

a16z has a clear advantage over other firms: the insane amount of dry powder at its disposal. Just three months ago, [the firm raised \\$9 billion in new capital](#), and its check-writing capabilities could see founders receiving nearly double the capital that YC offers in its [recently expanded standard deal](#).

Another way to compete would be to adopt a more relaxed attitude about ownership, which [we've seen even the most disciplined firms do in sectors under the spotlight](#).

A startup that gets accepted into the program may join for the stamp of approval, but it will gladly stay when it knows that a16z doesn't just have the ability to make a first check, but lead literally every following round until the company is ready to go public. And given today's [founder friendly-ish market](#), that stability could resonate.

In a lot of ways, the new a16z program is a continuation of a trend that we've seen established venture capital firms follow over the past two years to keep up with all the new deals in the market.

For example, a16z has been investing in microfunds for years as a way to keep an eye on promising founders. Additionally, a number of venture firms such as NextView and Accel have created in-house accelerator programs.

The perks are obvious: Early checks mean more upside, less competition, and a way to diversify across different sectors without as much risk. (Note: Sequoia Capital, one of a16z's most formidable rivals, [was an early investor in an entity run by Y Combinator](#)).

a16z's program feels predictable, if not delayed, compared to other firms out there. The firm notoriously left the seed stage a few years ago to avoid the appearance of conflicts of interest — a dynamic some founders still associate with the firm today — before returning to an aggressive cadence of early-stage investing.

a16z START is yet another piece of evidence for the thesis that the early-stage fundraising market, [despite some valuations pullback](#), still has hungry investors.

So, why does a16z need its own Y Combinator? The better question appears to be: Why not?

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Klarna and Deel eye IPOs,
and Stripe embraces
crypto

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This week we're looking at how fintech heavyweights such as Klarna and Stripe are incorporating crypto into their strategies, which companies are planning for IPOs, one fintech's Super Bowl ad, Stripe's new lead of startups and venture capital, and more!

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The big story



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Klarna CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski posted in a February 8 [post on X](#) that he and Klarna would “[embrace crypto](#).” The Swedish buy now, pay later giant is also said to be planning a U.S. initial public offering in April with a target of a \$15 billion valuation, according to the [Financial Times](#). Even though this would be about one-third lower than its [peak valuation of \\$45.6 billion](#) in 2021, it would still be “one of the biggest listings of the year,” reports FT. Klarna was [valued at \\$6.7 billion](#) when it raised \$800 million in 2022.

Dollars and cents



KHAZNA .

IMAGE CREDITS :KHAZNA

Khazna, an Egyptian fintech startup that offers financial services tailored toward low- and middle-income workers, recently [secured \\$16 million](#) in pre-Series B funding, bringing its total funding to over \$63 million.

Rapyd Financial Network is [looking to raise \\$300 million](#) in a new funding round that would value the global payments platform at \$3.5 billion, a considerable decrease from its [approximately \\$9 billion valuation](#) set in 2021.

Fintech-turned-HR outfit **Deel** is trying to lay the groundwork for an IPO. On February 4, it said its

annual revenue run rate [climbed to \\$800 million](#) in 2024 after growing by 70%. It also sold \$300 million in secondary shares to General Catalyst and an unnamed “sovereign investor.”



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Superlogic, a startup that helps give consumers a way to apply rewards points toward experiences such as courtside tickets to NBA games, has [raised \\$13.7 million](#) at a \$200 million valuation.

A clearer picture of [Bench’s downfall](#) is emerging thanks to newly released [bankruptcy filings](#). The records show that the Canada-based startup, which ironically enough offered cloud accounting software for small businesses, consistently struggled to reach profitability. It burned through \$135 million from its founding in 2012 to September 2024. By the time of [its collapse](#), Bench was forced to shut down due to a “liquidity crisis,” the records say. The company has since been acquired by Employer.com. However, Bench’s bankruptcy offers a window into the dangers of too much debt for startups. Charles Rollet [takes a look](#).

Stripe has [closed on its \\$1.1 billion purchase](#) of stablecoin platform Bridge — marking the payment giant’s [largest acquisition to date](#) and tangible push into crypto.

In other Stripe news, TechCrunch learned that the payments giant has tapped Asya Bradley [to serve as its Startups and VC Partnerships lead](#). Bradley previously held revenue roles at Synapse and Sila. She’s also an LP in venture funds Ganas Ventures and Cowboy Ventures.

Philadelphia Eagles’ star running back Saquon Barkley has not only [become an investor in fintech startup Ramp](#), but he was also the star of the company’s first Super Bowl commercial.

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